

The Principle of Personality in Philosophy

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I.

By the principle of personality I understand the thought that the human being, at every point and in every respect, is to be treated—by others and by himself—as an end, never merely as a means. Even where the human being serves—serves other human beings, serves society, serves a cause, an idea—he is at the same time to be an end himself, in that the serving ought to lead to the development and ennoblement of his own being, of its individual distinctiveness. It is an ideal that is set up in this principle, which was first formulated with full clarity and definiteness by Immanuel Kant (1785). In the Nordic countries it was asserted with great emphasis by Erik Gustaf Geijer in Sweden (1842), from whom the name “principle of personality” derives. Whereas Kant set up this principle in opposition partly to the principle of authority, partly [6] to an external morality of utility and happiness, Geijer set it against the romantic-conservative “historical school,” which laid weight solely on institutions and traditions, such as these had once come to develop, and he found more and more that everything

he had worked for in literature, in politics and in religion was contained in this principle. In Denmark the principle was stated, especially in the religious field, at about the same time (1846) by F. C. Sibbern and Søren Kierkegaard.—If we followed the history of the principle further back, we should come on the one side to Christianity and the weight it laid on the individual soul, on the other to the Socratic insistence on the significance of self-knowledge and self-appraisal.

The argument for the principle is very different in its various representatives. To this I shall return later, when I shall at the same time examine whether this principle can be proved conclusively at all. Here I want to try to set out everything that it contains. It is first and foremost set up as an ethical and religious principle. But I believe that it also contains points of view of great importance for a right understanding of the relation of science to life. It has an intellectual, not merely an ethical and religious, significance, and I shall examine it from all three of these sides. What Geijer said of his time, that it “is a time that suffers from its own thoughts,” in that “the inner world totters in its foundations, in its faith, its conviction, its knowledge”—and that “the fundamental and mother thought that here wants out and forces its way, and in whose birth-pangs the world trembles,” is precisely the principle of personality,¹—this surely still holds to this day. The crisis is not over; it has only taken somewhat different forms than in Geijer’s time. Geijer’s words aptly say that here is a thought that has worked its way forward involuntarily, but that can come into its full right only by becoming the object of clear consciousness. [7]

When we now begin with the intellectual significance of the principle of personality, we meet the objection that in science the point is precisely to look away from our personality, its striving, its pleasure and pain, its hope and its fear. Ought we not precisely to divest ourselves of our personality if we want to be investigators, if we want to find the great laws of existence, which hold for each and all? In science we are led into a common world. But every personality has its own little world, different for each, like the world of dreams in contrast to the waking reality common to all. Can personality here demand more than to be allowed to live in the world of its dreams, so long as science does not draw this, too, under the strict jurisdiction of its research?— [8]

¹*Samlade Skrifter* (1853) I 6, p. 287.

I go for a moment into this analogy between dream and reality on the one side, personality and science on the other. Psychology shows us that the same laws hold for consciousness in dreaming and in the waking state. In both there appears a need and a capacity to sum up and order all experiences, all sensations, feelings and thoughts. In dreams this happens in a more erratic and seemingly irregular way—now with genius, now stupidly. In the waking state it happens more according to definite theoretical [9] and practical points of view (although here too both stupidity and genius may occur). The relation between personality and science is analogous. It is a kindred need and a kindred capacity that are at work in both. We speak of personality only where a striving for connection in the mental life appears, a striving to gather all psychical elements and lead them in definite directions. Continuity and concentration are the distinguishing marks of personality. Science is only a particular, specially shaped form of this characteristic. Insofar as there is an opposition between personality and science, it should be established that it has its place within personality, —that it concerns the relation between personality as a whole and one of its special expressions of life.

One of the chief tasks of philosophy is precisely to investigate how and why scientific consciousness develops as a special form of personal life. Philosophical reflection seeks to answer the question how the nature of the human mind expresses itself, both in the work that leads to a great common picture of the world, and in the [10] work that perhaps acquires significance only by bringing harmony and order into the individual's own little world. This little world need not be a world of dreams; here the analogy mentioned above cannot simply be applied; in any case there is a special problem here, to which we shall return later.

It is critical philosophy that has maintained with the greatest energy that the work of thought in science cannot be concluded, and cannot be understood in its full significance, without regard to the nature and conditions of conscious beings. Every objective truth has a subjective foundation, even if one cannot infer this truth from the subjective foundation in and by itself.

The historical origin of science is to be found where the human being has had the experience that she can reach her ends only by quite definite ways. She would rather reach them immediately. Only when forced by experience does she go by detours. And

she then stands face to face with a connection to which she must bow. Here occurs her first meeting with the necessity that science uncovers at one point after the other. [11] Science demands resignation. Here the human being thinks in order to live. The work of thought, and thereby of personality, is here only a means. But it is a means that can itself become an end, by becoming the object of immediate interest. It becomes an independent task to come to know the great connection within which personal life is lived, to find an order of things more comprehensive than the individual's own little world. And then the human being can live in order to think. She grows with the greater ends she thus sets herself. Personality becomes richer the greater the circle of experiences it embraces, provided only that it can gather them into a harmonious unity, or at least divine and seek such a unity. It is easy enough to concentrate oneself when there is only a poor and limited content to sum up, when no great oppositions, no wealth of experiences, lay claim to the psychical energy. The world of personality must be widened if this energy is rightly to come to light.

Science and its history first become comprehensible when there is an inner connection between scientific work and the whole life and activity of personality. Scientific [12] work presupposes an energy and an enthusiasm, an *amor intellectualis*, which is not possible without an inner connection between science and personality. And such a connection in turn presupposes that it is no alien power to which personality bows when through research it is led to acknowledge a great connection that points far beyond its own little world. The longing to find truth by the way that science points out is only a special form of the longing for agreement with oneself amid all the manifold and changing experiences—the longing of which the very being of personality consists. And even where personality keenly feels the opposition between its own little world and the immeasurable world, reaching beyond all human works and ends, to which science opens our eyes, it belongs precisely to the nobility of personality, as well as to its duty, to find by its own strength, by straining the energy of its own thought, the great laws that condition its existence and its values. Personality is purified by seeing its existence conditioned and limited by the great connection of things. [13]

Not all sides of personality are called upon to the same degree by scientific work. In his research the human being must start from definite points of view, follow

definite paths, develop his life of thought according to certain definite methods, which are indeed special shapings of personal life in general, but which in the course of mankind's long labor of thought have proved indispensable. Science works with certain fundamental concepts or fundamental predicates, which of old are called categories, and which together make up an armor suited both to personality and to the resistance that the work of thought has to overcome.² Personality, insofar as it appears in this armor, has sometimes been called "the pure I," in contrast to "the empirical I," which shows us personality in the whole of its individual reality, with all its experiences, ideas, wishes and drives. The pure I is the I of the solitude of thought, of the study and the laboratory, the I that works strictly with "the categories." But it is [14] only a particular shaping, made necessary by the division of labor, of this same I that manifests itself in ideas, wishes and drives. There is no absolute difference between them, and their mutual relation can appear in countless shades in different individuals. There are investigators who are transformed into quite different people when they step out of the solitude of thought into ordinary life. But that is an imperfection that points to an unresolved disharmony in personal life itself.

On this point stands the conflict of our day between criticism and pragmatism. The former is inclined (already in its founder, Immanuel Kant) to regard "the pure I," the sum of the forms of investigating thought (the categories), as given once and for all, independent of all experience and history (including the history of science itself). The latter is inclined (both in the form Ernst Mach and in the form William James has given it) to regard the forms and presuppositions that are necessary for scientific work as conditioned merely by external tasks and practical interests, without standing [15] in any inner connection with human nature itself. In my view this contradiction falls away when one examines more closely the nature and development of the particular forms of thought. In my book on "Den menneskelige Tanke" I have worked in this direction, and have thereby been strengthened in the conviction that in science the human being stands neither merely as a means for the application of certain pure forms nor merely for the satisfaction of tasks given from without.

Since science thus in its origin points back to human personality and appears

²Cf. on this *Den menneskelige Tanke, dens Former og dens Opgaver* (1910), Chap. III.

as a particular form of the work that every personality has to perform in order to assert and develop itself, its personal character becomes visible from another and more individual side at the conclusion of scientific work. An absolute conclusion, a conclusion once and for all, is not possible, since life and experience always go on. But every individual investigator shall and must stop at a definite point, where inner or outer causes prevent him from getting further. And then he will naturally seek a survey, a summing-up, a rounding-off. He will at the same time attempt a [16] glimpse into the unexplored, if not unexplorable, regions, as one throws light into the darkness with an electric searchlight. Here it is not only "the pure I" that is at work; the other sides of personality will cooperate to a greater or lesser degree. One sees it, for example, in the attempts of natural scientists to set their results in relation to their whole view of the world. And one sees it when the historical investigator passes from the critical examination of the sources to the writing of history; this demands a rounding-off in which the personality of the investigator asserts itself more than during the critical work. One sees it still more in philosophy, when it passes from criticism to system, from analysis to synthesis.

Philosophical systems ought never to have wanted to be more than individual roundings-off. Rounding-off can be justified even if conclusion is impossible. Goethe characterized his research by the principle "Nie geschlossen, oft gerundet!" And in the rounding-off the individual character ought to be expressly acknowledged. The really significant systems do not lose by this, but precisely thereby gain a special interest. Even the system that is often regarded as the most objective and impersonal [17] of all—Spinoza's—proves on closer examination to be pervaded by the personality of its founder; it is the bond that unites the many series of thoughts into a unity. Through the whole course of thought one feels the master's fearless consistency, his great resignation and his inward absorption in the work of thought, which for him was a religion. It is not least this that makes many turn back again and again, and with ever new gain, to this work of art of thought.

The interest that the history of philosophy offers rests to a great extent on this personal element. The history of philosophy can be regarded as a great dialogue, whose particular speeches come from personalities of research, each of whom, on the

foundation of the science and culture of his time, has developed a type of thought, a more or less essential view of existence. For philosophy its history has, precisely on account of the principle of personality, greater significance than for other sciences. In this, as in other respects, it stands between science and art. And for many its great power of attraction lies precisely in this.

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II.

A right understanding of science requires that one see in it a fruit of personal work. This excludes both fear of its results and presumption about them.

But personality is not only the subject of science. It is at the same time itself one of the objects of science. Science turns to it as to a given matter, which is to be understood and explained in its nature and in its origin. The personal factor that cooperates in all science can and ought itself to be made an object of science. The world is understood through the human being (*ex analogia hominis*); our knowledge of the world is conditioned by the faculties and forms of human thought. But the human being is himself a part of the world, which can be understood only in its connection with the rest of the world. The human being is therefore understood through the world (*ex analogia universi*).

As Pascal has said: "In space the world encompasses (*comprend*) me, but in thought I encompass (*comprends*) the world." [19]

The two ways of regarding things do not conflict with each other. They are two points of view that must both be adopted, and that stand in inner interaction. Human thought, which works at solving the riddles of existence, has itself developed within existence. The presuppositions that condition and limit our view of the world themselves have a history. It is not least the necessity of this double point of view that makes an absolute conclusion of knowledge impossible. We cannot use both points of view at once. We cannot stand on our head and on our feet at once; but we can (perhaps) do first the one and then the other.

Against making personality an object of science an interesting objection has, however, been raised by one of the finest thinkers of present-day Germany, Heinrich Rickert, in his work "Die Grenzen der naturwissenschaftlichen Begriffsbildung"

(1901–1902). Rickert maintains a sharp opposition between natural science and history (the science of mind): the former concerns the universal and general, that which is constantly repeated;—the latter has as its object something that happens only once [20] (*das Einmalige*), individual events and individual figures. The purely natural-scientific method aims at finding general concepts and laws under which the individual phenomena can be subsumed as examples. The historical sciences, on the other hand, stop at individual totalities. The concepts of natural science are general concepts; the historical concepts are individual concepts!³

Against this view I set the claim that in the world of nature, as well as in that of mind, general concepts and laws are in the end only means of understanding the individual and the historical (*das Einmalige*). It is the pride of science that it can form concepts and laws that hold for countless individuals and events. The capacity for this was already for Plato, the typical figure of Greek science, a divine gift that ever anew filled his soul with admiration. Indeed, according to Plato the gods themselves [21] were subordinate to the eternal ideas and rejoiced to look up to them. But no really given phenomenon, whether in the world of nature or in that of mind, is exhaustively explained by being regarded as an example of a general concept or of a general law. To understand natural phenomena as well as historical phenomena an interplay of laws is required. The laws are the means of thought which by their cooperation make the origin and development of a phenomenon comprehensible. The solar system, the earth, the organism, the personality, society—these are examples of individual totalities, whose history it is the task of science to write, with the help of the concepts and laws it is able to find. The history of science clearly shows us the rising significance of the concept of development. In the end the task appears of writing the biography of “the world”—insofar as “the world” can appear as a rounded whole.

It is by no means the case that it is only history that exhibits the single occurrence (*das Einmalige*). Nor does absolute repetition occur in nature. No event ever recurs in quite the same way. The unchangeableness of nature is only apparent. It is a [22] great world drama (or perhaps rather an epic) that natural science and history are to

³“Von den Individuen gibt es keine Naturwissenschaft, weil sich nichts Besonderes mehr ihnen unterordnen lässt, im Vergleich zu dem sie noch als ein allgemeiner Begriff oder als eine ‘Natur’ aufzufassen wären.” Über die Grenzen der naturwissenschaftlichen Begriffsbildung, p. 295.

interpret together. In it no scene, no situation, no speech occurs more than once, if one pays close attention to all particulars, all nuances and accents.

It is a great and lofty ideal that is hereby set for science. But it is necessary for a right understanding of the significance of science. Natural science approaches it by means of the great hypotheses that are raised on the foundation of laws that have been found. The laws always concern simple and elementary relations; afterwards the task presents itself of how these relations assert themselves within the wholes, of different kinds and different degrees, that experience exhibits. Whereas natural science goes from the elements to the totalities, the science of mind stands more directly before totalities (events, personalities, societies), and such as do not let themselves be resolved into elements as easily as the material totalities that natural science treats. This, however, conditions only a difference of degree, not a difference of kind.

It has long been recognized that the more comprehensive our concepts are, the [23] poorer they are in content, and conversely. But it is not richness of content that is to be subordinated to the comprehensive abstractions; it is the latter that are to be used to understand and appreciate the former. The most generally valid sciences, logic and mathematics, are used (apart from their own independent interest) as means and presuppositions for the more special sciences. The difficulties increase and the riddles become more numerous the nearer we come to the individual totalities. But these always indicate the ultimate objects and tasks of research.

When it is said that we cannot form proper concepts of the individual (*das Einmalige*), since there is nothing that can be subsumed under it, the answer must be that the concept we form of an individual phenomenon, an event (e.g. the French Revolution) or a historical personality (e.g. Luther), includes all the different sides, properties, situations and stages of development that can contribute to its complete characterization. The “historical” concepts too, not only those of natural science, then [24] comprise a multiplicity. A distinction must be made between two kinds of individual concepts. If I think of a historical personality in a definite situation (e.g. Luther at Worms), I can form a concrete individual concept of him; it has an intuitive character and bears the stamp of the memory image or the image of fantasy. But no historical personality is exhausted in a single situation (any more than in a single property or at

a single phase of development). My complete concept of it must correspond to all the situations in which it appears, and it can then be called a typical individual concept. The great difficulty with individual concepts is precisely to decide the relation between the concrete and the typical. Is it the young Luther, he who burned the papal bull, or is it the old Luther, the organizer and dogmatist, who is to be decisive for our final concept of Luther? Which of the phases of the French Revolution is to determine its (typical) concept for us?

The solution surely lies in this, that the typical concept of the individual states the law according to which the transition takes place from the one stage and the one [25] situation to the others. It is the law of change that gives expression to the essence of an individuality. If this law can be discovered, the nature of the individual can be found again in each of its stages, and in the preceding stage one can trace the ones that follow.⁴ Every psychological and historical account works at finding such a law. Every good biography at any rate lets us divine it.

Art can show us only the concrete, pictures of individual situations and actions in which a personality comes to light, not the whole sequence of pictures that would be needed to form a typical concept. Hence conflicting interpretations can arise of artistically represented figures, for example of Hamlet. And yet art is able to carry out individualization better than nature and history as a rule do.

However precarious it may be to form typical individual concepts, these nevertheless appear in the end as the highest task of thought. In order to find general laws, science must often disregard the fact that everything experience shows us has an individual character, appears as a whole, be it simple and elementary. There are many degrees of individuality—all the way from a cloud in the sky or a heap of sand on the shore to a human personality or a human society. All too often one meets the idea that nature “begins” with a chaos of elements and forces without quality and definite direction, and that all totalities and individualities are their products. In our textbooks we begin with the simple and pass on to the compound, because understanding is most easily reached in this way. But what we know of the elements, of the simple, is in [26]

⁴*Leibniz*, the real founder of the concept of individuality, already expressed this thought. It is “la loi de l’ordre,” “la loi du changement,” that constitutes the individuality of each being. *Lettre à Basnage* 1698. (Opera philos. ed. Erdmann, p. 151).

fact always gained by analysis of the total connection, by abstraction from individual phenomena that can vary infinitely.⁵

The consideration set out here acquires a special significance when personality [27] becomes an object of science. For personality is not only the example of an individual totality that lies nearest to us. It is at the same time the most pronounced example of one, in that it exhibits the most intimate cooperation of elements and forces that lies within our experience.

We now turn to psychology, the empirical science of personality, to see what it can teach us about the nature of personality in itself.

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III.

In all the empirical sciences the decisive definitions come at the end, not at the beginning. Psychology works its way slowly toward a concept of personality. All its different methods—observation, description, comparison, experiment—lead directly or indirectly to this goal. When we already now try to set up—and in what precedes have presupposed—a concept of personality, this can be done only by way of hypothesis.

As a characteristic trait of personal beings, unity in all states and undertakings must first be emphasized. We call a human being a personality in so much the more pronounced a degree, the more all his thoughts, feelings and strivings are directed toward one goal,—the more concentration there is in his spiritual life,—the greater continuity there is in his strivings. In spite of all changes and shifting situations [29] a common law, a stamp of unity, or at least a connection, must appear in him. In the most exalted way this shows itself when the human being is subject to great oscillations, caught in strong conflicts, and yet does not in the dark hours deny what on the heights of life stood before him as true and right.

Personality is maintained—like all mental life—only by an uninterrupted spiritual work, in which psychical energy manifests itself. It is a constant struggle to hold together and harmonize a given multiplicity of sensations, thoughts, feelings, drives

⁵Cf., with respect to the question treated in this section, my presentation of “totality and development” as special categories, “Den menneskelige Tanke,” pp. 218–237.

and interests, which go in different directions or stand indifferent to one another. The greater this multiplicity and difference is, the more spiritual work it takes for the mental life to hold together. And the more intimate the connection and the concentration are, the greater the psychical energy that must be spent on this work.

It was this concept that I laid at the foundation when, some thirty years ago, I worked out my presentation of psychology. It had developed in me through criticism [30] of the older English psychology (the so-called “association psychology”), which sought to explain the mental life—and thereby personality—as the product of a mechanical joining together of psychical elements (independent sensations, ideas, etc.), which would stand in roughly the same relation to personality as a heap of stones to the house that is built. The task now became to show that, as long as the mental life persists, connection and unity are never wholly lacking in it, although these can take very elementary forms. I relied here especially on the study of mental illnesses, which proves that mental illness consists above all in a dissolution of the connection within the mental life, in a weakening of psychical energy. Later my view was confirmed by Pierre Janet’s works, especially by his description of “psychasthenia,” a spiritual weakness characterized by this, that no psychical content, no psychical elements, have dropped out, but that the energy for holding together and concentrating is lacking, so that patients who suffer from this illness are unable to make decisions, to take resolutions. What is lacking is what Janet aptly calls “psychical tension” (*tension* [31] *psychologique*), which corresponds to what I call synthesis or psychical energy.

In the child psychical energy is not yet so developed that a strong and lasting concentration can become possible. Spiritual development consists not merely in a manifold content, taken up through experience and tradition, but first and foremost in the energy that brings about an inner connection. The dream state is characterized above all by lacking firm connection and consistency in the content of consciousness. Like the child’s consciousness, it has a sporadic character. In it one idea passes easily into another; the situations change without this as a rule arousing surprise and without any explanation of the change being sought. In waking consciousness definite directions are held fast and followed, and the changes are motivated, or, if motivation seems to be lacking, they become riddles. Even if there is here only a difference of

degree, since there are, after all, waking dreams too, this difference nevertheless clearly shows the significance of psychical energy, especially since we have reason to assume that dream consciousness marks a state between the conscious and the unconscious.

It is not, however, only from weakness or lack of development that the particular elements of the mental life—sensations, thoughts, feelings, etc.—can appear independently and without closer connection. By attention and analysis we can also bring out and isolate particular elements and, as far as possible, consider them each by itself. We must distinguish in order to be able to apprehend clearly. But such distinctions are more or less artificial. They are reflections, the work of afterthought, and must not be confused with what immediate experience offers. The more we are able to immerse ourselves in our purely immediate and involuntary experiences, the more clearly our mental life shows itself to flow as a continuous stream, in which no element can be isolated from the others without being changed in its character. This continuous nature of immediate psychical experiences has in the most recent time been demonstrated in a brilliant and forceful way by William James and Henri Bergson. [32]

Finally, experimental psychology too points in the same direction. Its real founder, Fechner, proved that the particular sensations do not arise independently of one another but are woven into one another, in that after a very strong stimulation of the sense organs a stronger stimulus than usual is required for a sensation of a certain strength to arise. The so-called contrast effects, too, testify to the great connection even in our elementary mental life. The color green appears more pronounced (“saturated”) after red, which is its complementary color, than after other colors. The absolute independence of the sensations is only apparent. [33]

And if we consider the matter from the physiological side, we are led in the same direction. Whatever the relation between soul and body may be, it remains certain that the mental life is extraordinarily intimately bound to the nervous system. But the significance of the latter lies in this, that it is a great organ of concentration, through which all the parts of the body stand in close connection and interaction, so that a closed and concentrated behavior of the organism as a whole thereby becomes possible. And the higher and more energetically developed the mental life we have reason to assume in a living being, the greater the role played by the nervous system, [34]

and the more centralized it is. In the outer, sensible appearance, too, the stamp of unity of the mental life, and thereby of personality, manifests itself.

It is only in those beings whose mental life has reached a higher degree of unity and clarity that we speak of personality. Personal life can appear in an enormous number of different degrees; to a great extent the difference between the various individuals rests on such a difference of degree in the intensity of concentration. Only in the case of human beings does one speak of personality. The mental life of the animal must, according to all experience, be assumed to be partly so simple, partly so changeable and incoherent, that it can most nearly be imagined as analogous to our dream life.

In what precedes we have defined the concept of personality only from the formal side. We have spoken of energy and concentration, of unity and connection. But the content too, which is gathered into unity, has its significance. Two personal beings with the same capacity for concentration can nevertheless be very different, on account of the different content in which they are absorbed and around which they gather themselves, and the different direction in which their energy is released. In the [35] real respect personality receives its stamp from embracing a central content, a ruling interest and striving, which conditions the direction in which the concentration takes place and the psychical energy is used. Every particular experience, thought, mood, resolution receives its definite place within the personality through its relation to a fundamental value, which constitutes the real distinguishing mark of the individual personality, just as the degree of energy of concentration constitutes its formal distinguishing mark. The little world that every personality embraces has, at every time, at every stage of development, a center, in relation to which all the other elements in personal life are determined in value and significance. To know oneself is to become conscious of this central interest, this fundamental value, which constitutes what one might call the real I. If there were no such constantly active elements within us, we should be strangers to ourselves. There can be constant elements of a purely peripheral kind within us; but the deeper self-knowledge presupposes central elements, and it therefore makes a comic impression when Holberg's Jeppe recognizes himself by his [36] hollow tooth. Such a peripheral element cannot determine the place of all the other

elements in the inner order of the world.⁶

In personal life a crisis arises if the central elements change. This can happen through sudden catastrophes or through long periods of doubt and unrest; but it can also happen slowly and imperceptibly, so that only afterwards do we discover that an essential change has taken place with us and within us. Something can work its way forward within us that quite involuntarily determines our striving, but of which we become conscious only later. An example that lies close at hand here is Geijer's relation to the thought he gave the name principle of personality. It arose in him at a late point in his life, in his fifty-fifth year, but he then discovered that he had long followed it without himself knowing it. In a letter he wrote on his last birthday (1847), he speaks of it in the following way.⁷ "There is a fundamental thought in my whole [37] life which stands out ever more clearly, and which is not my work; for it has led me and guided me right up to this day. Should I give it a name, it is none other than the much disputed principle of personality, whose prophet I have become almost against my will. By this I mean that I have kept away and warded off from me everything that could hinder and check the development of my own innermost being. This has mostly happened without my own cooperation. But this has now come over me, and it becomes clear to me that what I have fought for in literature, in politics and in religion is really this my innermost personality and its right, in the best sense."

Thus the history of the development of the principle of personality itself offers an example of a chief point in the nature and conditions of personal life. We are led to see that personality cannot be said to be exhaustively determined by what, at a given moment, comes to light in clear consciousness and with full understanding. Just as it is assumed that in organic life seemingly sudden changes (mutations) can occur, through which new types can arise, so too in the spiritual field changes in the [38] guiding lines can be prepared by a quiet growth, changes which to the superficial observer may seem inexplicable, although they have their cause in what has gone on in the innermost core of the mental life. We have here an important example of the difference between concrete and typical individual representations that was set forth in the preceding section. The typical concept of a personality can be reached

⁶On the difference between the formal and the real I, cf. my "Psyкологи" V B, 5.

⁷*Samlade Skrifter* I, 1, p. XXXVIII.

only by following it through its different stages of development, and it is often the later stages that direct attention to the content and significance of the earlier stages. Descriptive psychology has a large field here. And it is to be hoped that, when the sense for personal life, its forms and its phases, develops still more than hitherto, significant work can be done here. Hitherto dogmatic and doctrinaire conceptions of various kinds have hindered uninterrupted work in this direction. Descriptive psychology approaches the boundary between science and art; but through clarity of conception and through the use of the comparative method it can conquer new ground for science.

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IV.

From the intellectual significance of the principle of personality I now pass to its practical significance, which is the original one.

Every principle sets up a demand on our thought or on our will. The principle of personality makes demands in both directions. I have tried to show what demands it makes on the life of thought. The practical demand it makes becomes, as I shall now try to show, of great importance for ethics and the philosophy of religion.

In Kant and Geijer alike, in Kierkegaard and Sibbern, the principle of personality is set up in a critical and polemical direction against the dominion of society and tradition over individual personalities. It demands their free and independent development. But it nevertheless contains within it the possibility of letting the social as well as the individualistic conception of human life and human action come into its own. [40]

From a purely social point of view it is emphasized that the individual always arises within a society. An isolated individual does not exist. The individual conscience itself, the innermost thing in the human being, is a product of social life, a social inheritance. The individual virtues are socially conditioned. And on the other hand the individual, with his longing and his striving, is vanishingly small in relation to the life of society, which goes on through countless generations. He is only a drop in the ocean. His happiness, his knowledge, his conscience acquire a vanishingly small significance compared with the great and lasting course of development of the race and of society.

And the only measure of the individual's significance lies in the contribution he is able to make to this course of development.

The individualist answers for his part: where should the significance of society be sought, if not in the security and support it gives to the development of individual personalities? The value of a society is measured by the degree to which it fulfills this task. This is the only possible measure, already for the good reason that society [41] consists of individuals and exists only in and through them.

If the social conception makes the individual a means for society, the individualistic conception makes society a means for the individual.

This contradiction does not appear as long as life is lived essentially under the involuntary guidance of instincts and traditions. But every development of culture comes to a point where the individual no longer feels at one with society, but where society and its demands stand as mere tradition, mere authority, perhaps as a purely external power. It is such a time that, in Geijer's words, suffers from its own thoughts. Then—precisely as a result of social development—-independent personalities have developed; but society does not yet dare fully to acknowledge their independence, and they cannot acknowledge the value of society. It is really only in such times that philosophy arises. Philosophy thereby easily takes on an individualistic character at its origin. Greek philosophy, the thought of the Renaissance and the philosophy of the eighteenth century are significant examples of this. The philosophy of the nineteenth [42] century signifies—in both its romantic and its positivist main form—a reaction against this, just as the great workers' associations too, whose rise is among the greatest events of that century, have an anti-individualistic character. But the problem rises again and again, and we have entered the new century with it.

In this problem a definite distinction must be made between the historical and the philosophical way of looking at things. It is a fact that the individual develops within society. His very longing and his striving, his ethical ideas and the criticism he exercises upon tradition, cannot be understood if one starts merely from the individual person, thought of as isolated. The individual is to that extent a product of social causes. And society reaches far beyond the individual, both into the future and into the past. But does there follow from this with necessity an obligation for the individual

to bow under the laws of society and to work for its welfare? The individual can, after all, regard social development, whose fruit he himself is, as a mere fact, a result, which he, if he has the spiritual and physical power for it, now uses in the service of his own individual ends. It is of no use to speak of a social debt, which the individual is to pay off by working for the continued development of society; for the question is precisely why the individual should acknowledge this debt. Why should the individual not regard himself as sovereign? [43]

What individualism in its extreme forms asserts is really this, that personality is to be an end without being a means. It does not, however, conflict with the principle of personality that personality is a means, serves a cause, an idea, serves society—provided only that this serving is a means to a higher personal development for the individual himself. Man grows, as Schiller has said, with his greater purposes. But these greater ends he can find only in the life of society. Just as thought grows only by seeking truth, that is, by finding as great a connection as possible between as many experiences as possible, so the life of feeling and will grows only through the experiences that are had and the work that is done through taking part in the life of society and of the race. But the condition for this is that the forms and demands of society be so modified that social work—the paying off of “the social debt”—can serve to bring to development powers and possibilities that would otherwise slumber unused in the individual. Personality can make itself a means for society only when society also makes itself a means for personality. The possibility of this is the core of the so-called social question. In the whole of history we find great groups of human beings who were essentially treated as means, without society considering that it had duties toward them. All justified social reforms aim at abolishing this dualism of end and means. Society must, if it is to continue to exist, acknowledge the principle of personality, although this was originally stated from individualistic standpoints. [44]

Not all forms of individualism, however, overlook this view. Max Stirner proclaimed (in his book “*Der Einzige und sein Eigentum*,” 1845) a philosophy of the self as abstract as it was absolute, according to which there was nothing, either within us or outside us, whose demands we should acknowledge. As long as you believe in truth, he even says, you do not believe in yourself and are only a servant. Every right [45]

is a privilege. I acknowledge no right, and I do not care about being in the right, if only I have power!—Here society is not merely made into a means; it really disappears altogether. In contrast to this, an individualism or “anarchism” such as Kropotkin’s rests on the experience of the significance that involuntary association has for all living beings, and he has described it in an interesting way in his book “Mutual Aid” (1902). Kropotkin objects only to centralization, to the intervention of the state in the spontaneous social formations of smaller circles. In the relations of neighborhood life orders itself as of its own accord. What Kropotkin has no eye for is that these involuntary associations—such as the old guilds and crafts—can lead to stagnation in oppression and injustice, and that intervention may therefore be needed. But he is right in this, that the state ought not, without being forced to, intervene in the smaller circles in which life inevitably moves—for the same reason that society ought not to intervene in the free development of the individual personality, unless this becomes [46] necessary out of regard for the free development of other personalities. It is in the inner life of individual persons that the new forces and thoughts have their origin which can carry the life of society forward. The germ of the future sprouts there. It is thus for its own sake that society ought to acknowledge the principle of personality. Its real power shows itself in the strength and independence with which individual persons can live their lives within its framework.

One often meets in modern sociologists a certain mystical conception of the concept of society, in that they assume a “social” origin for ideas and feelings. If by this it is meant only that ideas and feelings develop in individuals through interaction with others, it is quite correct. But when “society” is appealed to as a cause, it is mysticism. Society as such can no more produce law, morality and religion than it can produce poetry and science. The “folk songs” were not composed by “the people” as a whole, but by individual singers whose names are forgotten, because their work at once became the property of all and because it underwent, in passing through many hands, changes that often made it into something other than it originally was. At earlier [47] stages of culture individual initiatives are easily forgotten. And it is precisely such stages of culture that sociologists prefer to occupy themselves with. At later stages the founding personalities play a greater role and are not so easily forgotten. An appeal

to “society” as the explanation of a phenomenon is in fact an *asylum ignorantiae*.⁸

This is not to deny what is justified in setting society and individual in opposition to each other. The concept of society implies that through the life and work of changing generations a capital is accumulated, a potential energy, which is laid down in institutions and traditions, indeed in language itself. Here is something that points beyond the individual,—back to the past and out toward the future,—something that belongs to no individual whatever. These are values that are bound, and that can be set free only through the work of individuals. A social order is valued not only according to the capital it thus has at its disposal, but also according to the way in which it is able to set it in motion. There can be dead values that get the appearance of life through social institutions. Whether values are living or dead can be decided only by whether or not they benefit the development of free personalities. For individual personalities are both the centers in which the values of life reveal themselves and the centers from which the work of finding and producing values goes out. [48]

On this whole view, society and individual stand at once as end and means for each other.

The highest ethical thought is this, that the individual personality is to develop itself in such a way that precisely through its independent and distinctive development it helps others, directly or indirectly, in the best way to develop themselves independently and distinctively. In this consists true justice, which Westermarck rightly calls “the flower of all social feelings.”⁹ It unites harmoniously self-assertion and devotion, the interests of the individual and of society. Through it society lives in individuals, not only outside or above them. In it the principle of personality comes into its full right. [49]

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V.

The question can now no longer be put off whether the principle of personality,

⁸It is of interest in this connection that E. G. Geijer’s defection from the “historical school,” which was the romantic forerunner of modern sociology, was occasioned precisely by his historical studies. (Saml. Skr. I, 8, p. 520). That is to say, he saw that it was no explanation of a phenomenon to appeal to “society” or “history” en bloc. And he saw “that history cannot give, but can indeed modify, the principle of action, and that this on the contrary must be each age’s own contribution.”

⁹Justice, the flower of all moral feelings. The origin and development of moral ideas. I p. 124.—Cf. my “Etik” III, 9; IX, 1; X, 4.

with which we have been occupied here, can be proved to be valid. In the immediately preceding lecture a motivation has indeed been given, but the question may arise whether this motivation does not itself rest on certain presuppositions. It consisted in this, that the said principle made possible the most harmonious development of society and the most intimate interaction between individuals.¹⁰ But this line of thought is naturally accepted as valid only by those for whom such a development of the human race stands as a good. It follows from the thought of universal human welfare. But the question is how matters stand with this thought itself. The answer to this question becomes decisive for the position of ethics as a science. [51]

Value can be measured only by value. And value points back to feeling—and about feelings, it is said, there is no disputing. Yet when a certain value is felt and acknowledged, one can infer from it what place other values consistently take in relation to the given value. In every human being—and approximately in every people and in every age—a certain fundamental value asserts itself, an interest that lies deepest and exerts the strongest influence. It corresponds to, or rather belongs to, what I call the real side of personality. And it decides what else acquires value, and what value it acquires. He for whom his own advantage is the fundamental value cannot without inconsistency make sacrifices for the benefit of other persons or for general ends. Conversely, he in whom love of mankind determines the fundamental value cannot without inconsistency act egoistically. Our ethical judgments are determined by our fundamental values, and these in their turn by our ruling feelings. [52]

But can one now claim that all human beings in all times and under all circumstances have the same fundamental values? That would certainly be an unpsychological and unhistorical claim, although thinkers such as Kant and Bentham, each in his own way, have made it. Fundamental values arise through psychological and historical processes that are never wholly completed. A fundamental value can never

¹⁰I first gave this proof in my *Etik* (VIII, 6, cf. XIII, 6), where I also criticized Kant's artificial argument. Geijer's proof (*Saml. skr.* I, 5, pp. 132–137) rests chiefly on this, that the human being discovers in every other human being a being of the same value as himself, and on this, that the human being can develop into a personality only in interaction with other human beings. But this does not exclude that the human being can make these kindred beings, whose cooperation he cannot do without, into mere means for himself!—Karl Marx (*Das Kapital* I p. 646) and Léon Bourgeois (in *La philosophie de la solidarité*. Paris 1902, p. 38) set up the proposition as self-evident, which a glance at history easily shows to be incorrect.

be set up as self-evident. It must grow forth, and in each individual case it depends on how far the growth has advanced. It is of no help to say that man grows with his greater purposes, for man must have grown in order to be able to set himself greater purposes and then grow further again through working for them. It serves no purpose, as Goethe has said, to tell the caterpillar that crawls in the dust that it will one day fly [53] from flower to flower.

The principle of personality as a general ethical principle presupposes the development of a consciousness of humanity, a universal love of mankind, such as first appeared in the last centuries before Christ through a peculiar fusion of Platonic and Stoic ideas. Since then it has had a long and changing history. It has had to struggle not only with the egoism of individuals, but also with the egoism of families, classes, nations and confessions. In the eighteenth century it broke through fully and set its definite demands upon civil society. But it is always a church militant. Therefore the consequences drawn from the general consciousness of humanity cannot be valid for all either.

Our thought can do no more than draw the consequences of certain definite presuppositions. It is the business of experience to decide whether these presuppositions are found everywhere and in all. This does not diminish the significance of thought, nor that of ethical thinking. Thought can only bring to clear consciousness what our presuppositions imply. And the significance of philosophical ethics also [54] depends precisely on this. It is to set out the consequences that can justly be drawn from a certain stage in the development of human feeling. Later it can be examined whether consequences from other stages of development coincide with them, and what difference different motivations and different presuppositions bring about.¹¹

Where ethical motivation reaches its limit, because its presuppositions are no longer acknowledged, the question arises how these presuppositions can be brought about. This becomes the business of moral pedagogy. It is through upbringing that fundamental values are formed. The word upbringing is taken here in the widest sense, so that the whole history of mankind is seen as one great upbringing. It is the business

¹¹This view of the scientific limitation and significance of ethics I developed long ago in my *Etik* (Chap. III). It is a joy to me to come upon a similar line of thought in Westermarck's "Origin and development of moral ideas" (I p. 17; 105; 122).

of psychology and sociology to show how this upbringing goes on involuntarily and unconsciously in individuals and in generations, and what means are available when one wants to bring up human beings fully consciously. [55]

Schopenhauer has said that it is hard to give grounds for morality but easy to preach morality. In the first part of his proposition he is right. But he is wrong in holding that it should be easy to preach morality, if by this is meant to lead human beings to such a development of their personality that by their own strength and desire they can find what is right. Not even in upbringing may a personal being be regarded and treated merely as a means, not even as a means for its own future. The caterpillar should be treated as a caterpillar until it becomes a butterfly. It is the great thought in Rousseau's pedagogy that the child is to be treated as a child and not merely as a future adult. The point, then, is to take the one who is to be brought up at the standpoint where he stands, and then, by the way of self-development and self-activity, to lead him to the level, the fundamental value, that can form the starting point for the conclusions one wants him to draw. Here Spinoza's words hold, that there is no way in which one can better show one's spiritual strength and capacity than by leading others to live according to their own clear conviction. [56]

If difficulties are thus bound up with the proof of ethical principles, there are also difficulties in carrying them through in each individual case. Even if the fundamental value is presupposed to be the same, the question nevertheless arises whether, starting from the common presuppositions, one can make the same ethical demands on all individuals. Individuals are different, both in the kind of their faculties and in the degree of psychical energy they have at their disposal. From this it follows that one cannot demand the same of all. Neither what is demanded nor how much is demanded can be fixed once and for all, but must be determined with regard to the nature and powers of the individual persons. The same burden weighs differently on different shoulders. There are people who have to fight a hard battle to fulfill the most elementary demands of self-control, which others meet quite involuntarily. The ethical work can be the same although the results turn out to be of very different value. Human beings are like runners who begin the race from very different starting points. For it cannot be denied that in the ethical respect, as in other respects, human [57]

beings are very differently equipped from the beginning.

It would conflict with the principle of personality to judge the individual by an abstract rule that takes no account of his individual conditions. The task becomes to individualize the ethical demands, so that each individual comes to perform the work that agrees with his personal conditions, and is thereby led onto a track that can lead further. Ethics is still far removed from such an individualization, and it requires, after all, great psychological discernment and great practical knowledge of human beings, as well as great patience. It is easier to systematize and to state universally valid propositions than to find the individual starting points in the particular cases. System and variation stand, in ethics as in biology, in sharp opposition to each other.

In concepts such as equity and pardon, however, individualization has long been acknowledged. Aristotle already sets up the concept of equity as a peculiar form of justice, made necessary by the fact that there are individual nuances that prevent [58] the application of a general law. And that pardon is granted can be justified in law only by the fact that legislation is not in a position to take account of all individual circumstances. Pardon is, says Jhering, the self-correction of justice.

It is, however, not only downward that individualization is required, but upward as well. There are not only individuals who begin their ethical development from a lower level than the average; there are also individuals who from the beginning are equipped with special conditions for ethical work. And by virtue of the principle of personality the ethical law must make greater demands on them than on others. They must themselves demand more of themselves than is demanded of others. They degrade themselves by contenting themselves with a minimum. It is their "duty" to add "merit." Schiller's Wilhelm Tell acknowledges this when he answers his wife's complaint that his countrymen always turn to him when something great is at stake, with the words: "Ein Jeder wird besteuert nach Vermögen!"

In the pedagogical respect the distinction between "duty" and "merit," on which Catholic theology lays so much weight, may be of importance. On the one hand it can [59] be hard enough to get everyone to fulfill the minimal demands one often thinks of at the word "duty"; on the other it may be necessary to warn against ethical ventures, against venturing further than one's powers allow. The difficulty lies in this, that

only by trying, by venturing, do we come to know the extent of our powers. By holding ourselves back we may cause powers and possibilities in us that could have developed in the work for greater ends to remain unused. And we do not come to know ourselves. Perhaps the attempt to perform a great action leads to our coming to know our limitation. Perhaps it leads even to a tragic outcome. But such, once and for all, are the conditions of life. As Longfellow has said: "Only those who brave its dangers comprehend its mystery."

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VI.

It remains to examine the significance of the principle of personality for the view of life and for faith, that is, its religious significance, when the word "religious" is taken in a wider sense. I believe that this significance is constantly growing, and that the most essential side of the present state of the religious problem depends upon it.

There are three elements that at any given time determine people's faith: science, tradition and personal experience. They play a very different role in different individuals, and even where they all assert themselves strongly, they are united with one another in very different ways, whereby the view of life acquires a distinct timbre. There are hardly two people in whom they appear in the same way or are joined in the same way. It would be an interesting study to penetrate into these differences. [61] Unfortunately such a study is possible only to an imperfect degree with regard to contemporaries.

More and more the first two elements, science and tradition, lead to the third, a personal experience of the course of life and the conditions of life.

a. Modern science, whose origin is to be sought in the century of the Renaissance, has exerted a great influence on the view of life above all through two main thoughts. The one is the idea of the immeasurability of the universe, of the unlimited extension of space and time. The limited stage on which the human being had until then been able to imagine the epic of existence spread out now appeared as a vanishing point. The other is the idea of a great lawfulness in the whole of nature, a lawfulness that is proved step by step by every change in the world of nature or of mind being explained

through its definite connection with other changes, without causes that lie outside a possible experience being called upon. This scientific concept of causality was applied first in the inorganic field, later also in the organic field, as well as in the spiritual field. [62]

The impressions this great change in the view of the world made on people's views of life were very different. In some it awakened enthusiasm, in that existence now more than before received the stamp of the sublime, while at the same time the conviction became clear that it is, in spite of everything, the same forces that are at work in human nature and in the infinite universe. In minds such as Bruno, Böhme and Spinoza this direction in the view of life asserts itself. In others this widening of the horizon, which turned the earthly stage into a vanishing point, awakened horror and dizziness, and led to a more passionate clinging to the old faith. Pascal is the great example of this direction. There were finally those who laid no weight at all on the great change in the picture of the world, who did not become conscious of its significance in principle, whether in their view of life they kept to the traditional faith or went their own ways.—Still to this day one finds these three standpoints toward the great problem.

One need not exaggerate the significance of science in order to be sure that it will exert a rising influence on views of life. It will not be possible to go around science. Pascal already said, after all, that if the earth really rotates, it rotates with believers and unbelievers alike. Science will work most through the quiet power that lies in its method, its way of asking and answering. Less and less will people brought up in this method be able to take mystical and anthropomorphic explanations as real answers to the riddles of experience. It is less the special results of science than the way of thinking it teaches people that will determine the future of views of life. In the first section of this presentation I sought, moreover, to bring out that it is no alien power that here comes to meet personality. The scientific interest and the scientific capacity are closely bound up with the nature of personality and bear its stamp. The deep longing for wholeness that is the innermost thing in personality lies at the foundation of science too. Science is the work of personality, which personality cannot deny. And it is of no help to close one's eyes to the widened horizon that science opens. We must see [64] ourselves, and the stage of all our work and all our interests, as smaller circles within

the great circle whose center is everywhere and whose circumference is nowhere. Nevertheless it will hardly ever become possible, starting from the points of view and results of science, to construct views of life for individual personalities each by itself. As we have seen (at the end of the second and third sections), it is indeed the ultimate and highest task of science to understand and explain individual totalities, and so personalities too; but here there can be question only of approximate assumptions, and science here approaches art. For the individual, the purely individual experiences of life will always be what is essential in the rounding-off that he involuntarily makes when his view of life is formed. A human being is more than an example of a general law, and even the human life that moves in the narrowest circle can make its contribution to the great common experience of mankind. In any case only the individual can know what the course of life and of fate is like at the particular place within existence where [65] his existence finds itself. "The least defends its place in life's wreath," a Danish poet has said.

b. In whatever way the religious traditions have arisen, their continued existence and the significance they still have for so many rest on the circumstance that the deepest experiences of life of countless generations have been laid down in dogma and cult. The history of religion shows us how ideas that were earlier religiously indifferent were taken into the service of religion under the influence of great movements in the life of feeling. So it went, for example, with the idea of the transmigration of souls in India and with the thoughts of Greek philosophy in the dogmatics of the Christian church. But within the religions they are regarded not merely as symbols of experiences of life. They are fixed as dogmas, which are to contain the solution of the riddles of life. They are torn up out of the living soil in which they grew. Yet more and more there reveals itself in the religious consciousness of our time a rupture between the symbolic-poetic and the literal-dogmatic conception. It appears ever more clearly that the riddles science cannot solve are not solved by the religious ideas either, already [66] for the reason that science both asks and answers otherwise than religion. The time is past when religion could satisfy all sides of the human mind. Intellectually it has lost the battle, however it may stand with other sides of the mind. In our day much noble strength goes to waste in the most independent minds through the work that

the rupture between religion and science calls forth,—strength that could have been used to lay the foundation of a conception of life based on one's own experience.

And yet it is not the relation between science and religion that is the most important thing in the present state of the religious problem. From both sides what can be said has been said, and continued discussion will bring nothing new. The decisive point lies rather in the relation between religion and personality. In contrast to the unchangeableness of religious tradition stands the free, personal experience of life, whose richness and fullness increase in the measure that the distinctiveness and the right of individual personalities are each acknowledged. Every human individual is one of the centers where the value of life is discerned, and one of the starting points [67] from which new values can be found or produced. It is not so much before the tribunal of science as before that of life that religion will in the future be brought. This happens by virtue of the principle of personality. For just as little as a human being is merely an example of a scientific concept, just so little is he to be merely a means for the preservation of a religious tradition.¹²

The religious need is a need to watch over the values of life beyond the limits [68] within which the human will can work for them. If the human being could himself absolutely secure his spiritual and material possessions, religion in any form would not arise. But as it is, hope or fear, enthusiasm or dejection, arise, according as one feels oneself on the heights of life or in its depths. The cults of the great religions give expression in the most exalted poetry to these opposed moods, which the epic of life brings with it and which will always assert themselves in everyone who lives life wholly and fully, and whose sympathy is not blunted and narrowed.

¹²Since I have in what precedes often referred to Erik Gustaf Geijer as one of the most important representatives of the principle of personality, I shall quote a remark that shows that in his religious conception too he remained true to his principle. "I am," he writes in a letter, "neither a church Christian nor even a Bible Christian ... I am a Christian on my own account. Thousands find themselves in the same position as I, indeed all who cannot content themselves with a mere faith in authority and who are compelled to build their own religion out of their own experience and reflection. *This individual element, now the only living thing in religion* ... yet points everywhere to a common goal." (Saml. Skr. I, 1, p. XXXII 7). (The italics are mine.) Yet Geijer, who stood under the strong influence of the romantic speculation of his time, also gave his principle of personality a theological and metaphysical significance, which is untenable, since every attempt in this direction leads to a play with analogies and allegories that can neither be consistently carried through nor confirmed by experience. Cf. on this my Religionsfilosofi § 32.

I will not prophesy about the religion of the future. I am a philosopher, not a prophet. But everything suggests that the more the real and lasting experiences of life gain influence on religious life, the more the symbolic-poetic conception of religious ideas will replace the literal-dogmatic one, and do so ever more consciously. And with this a great step will be taken toward a free, self-won human view of life.—

c. Science and tradition alike thus point toward personal experience of life. A [69] thoroughgoing individualization of the view of life is necessary. Personality is to set its stamp on its faith. Only thus does this become a testimony to how life moves at this particular place in the world. And as advanced psychological investigations lead us to see that individual differences are far greater and lie far deeper than has hitherto been assumed, the views of life of the future will probably exhibit greater oppositions than one could get a view of so long as the common confessional dogmas covered the mutually divergent conceptions and applications of an identically worded confession.¹³ It is a gleam of light in the darkness of the time that this side of the principle of personality is more and more acknowledged. If it is acknowledged fully, a wholly new conception of the ultimate problems will assert itself. For the time being the old dogmas struggle with the new doubt. Through this purgatory the decisive [70] victory is to be won for the principle of personality.

¹³Cf. the survey I have sought to give in my philosophy of religion (§ 36–43 & § 94–96) of individual differences that can acquire significance for the view of life.—We stand here at a point that has been strongly emphasized by Danish philosophers, all the way from Holberg to Sibbern and Kierkegaard. See on this my book “Danske filosofer” (1909).